

VOLTA

COLOPHON VOLUME 60



TOWSON HIGH SCHOOL

EDITORIAL STATEMENT

Volta is the word for the dramatic change in thinking, emotion, or argument between sections of a poem. As the title of this year's edition, *Volta* recognizes the shift in tone of our submissions. We are ecstatic to have received 250 literary submissions and over 100 art pieces in which we observed a departure from the tenebrous themes of past years and a hopeful turn towards quiet contemplation and appreciation of the natural world. We hope this edition reflects our commitment to ensuring Colophon remains a creative haven for THS students for many years to come.

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COLOPHON

A CREATIVE ARTS MAGAZINE



Casey Schultz, Complimentary Colors, Oil on Canvas

VOLUME 60 ☀ 2026

Towson High School
69 Cedar Ave
Towson, Maryland 21286

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Elle Russell, *Fihankra*, Oil on Wood

Elegy With Youth

by Elsa Stano

Home is our name for the dead sanctuary
where we keep memories of childhood

By framing old pictures of laughing babies
who don't have names anymore. The cold

magnets falls off the fridge, onto the new
kitchen tiles. There are the forgotten toys,

sleeping in the attic, carrying their own
weight of memory. My sister and I walk

Throughout the old house, trying to find
what we have been looking for the past

Eight years. I'm mad when I can't find my
youth anymore and my sister begins to cry.

Every room we enter is dark. Our eyes
blur from tears, we run to our parents bedroom

To wake us up from our nightmare and
return our souls back to our young bodies, and when

We open our eyes, she was sixteen and I
was seventeen, placed out of our skewed memory

We kneeled in front of our old house
To mourn our childhood reminiscences that

We made together, and we hoped
That we can figure out how to get them back

But we know where we live now with our
mother and father, and where we are buried.

WHEN PIGS FLY

by Teru Aoki

The wide
Sweeping
Adriatic Sea
A reflected sky
That cradles life

A world after war
Transformation and tension
In one

Where complicity turns
Men
Into swine;
A curse of regret and wrongdoing

Yet Red still soars

A flying ace,
First meant to chase a foreign enemy
Once with allies
Now alone,
Against domestic foes



Life with an unsatisfying purpose
Shame in what you become
Hating how the world changes

Fedora, greatcoat, boots and gloves
To hide from yourself
And avoid another's gaze
That waits for you

Pushed into an unwanted rivalry, you fight again
Someone behind you
With a future
That you want to protect

Engines growl, bullets pierce and pass
Fancy flying & a fistfight
To end the show, win or lose

Guard what you care for,
Your life follows suit.



Max Gerber, *Looming Lense*, Ink on Paper

La Belle Fleur

by Clay Schultz

Il y a une belle fleur que j'avais
regardé souvent dans la forêt.
Elle fleurit pendant seulement
un mois au printemps.

Et une année particulière
Une fille avait trouvé ma primevère.
Nous nous sommes assis sur le sol,
et nous avons joué ensemble.

Et tous les après-midi,
Nous avons exploré, joué et ri.
Jusqu'à la dernière lumière
De la nuit.

Mais quand le dernier pétale était
Tombé, c'était
Temps de dire
Au revoir à mon ami.

Et l'année suivante, J'ai attendu
près de notre fleur pour elle, qui n'est jamais venue.
Donc les années ont passé sans mon ami
De la campagne,

Et elle est devenue un souvenir de mon enfance
Mais quand même quelques jours au printemps
Je rends visite à notre fleur,
Avec la clé de mon amour.



Safora Noor, *Idyllic Countryside*,
Oil and Acrylic on Canvas

La Belle Fleur

La Belle Fleur is a poem written in French about a boy who meets and befriends a girl in the countryside. It draws on themes of spring and old friends to convey the idea that childish wonder is only temporary, which is what makes it so captivating.



Yanka Zhang, *Cord*, Digital

Two Windows, One Distant Light

by Diana Bobokulova

Our
Distance
Feels intimate
Because although
We don't speak
To each other
Anymore, we are
Yet to break
Our silent pact.
It's pathetic, yet
I find myself comforted
By the idea that
Despite our indifference
For one another, the past
We once shared is still on
Our minds whenever we gaze
At the moon we used
Adore together. If I were to
I'm at peace knowing that
Wouldn't answer, nor
Call back.

up
to

call,

you

B i r t h d a y

by Jemma Steinik

Candles light
Ruby flames
There are chirping voices
They sound like mourning doves

Freshness seeps away
Pores capture decay
Tongues swipe at sugar
But it only plants rot

The skin sloughs away every month
A new layer replaces it
Only a few months now

Better to be replaced
Rather than continue eroding



Sireen El-Awady, Weathercock House - Kobe, Japan, Embroidery

In the morning I watch
the Jagged edges of water
shape the greying bourn
Along the snowy banks
of a cold wintery path.

The dawdling steps of my mother
and shadow growing longer
as I trudge along behind her
hand in hand
feeling the comfort of her warmth.

And we make our way past the greying rocks
and the fallen trees
that line the shining edges,
As the morning rises to
the brightness of the afternoon.

Illuminated,
My mother's face coated in frost
the deepening creases of her forehead
And her cheeks,
like ice,
begin to crack.

Where will it take me?
I ask my mother.
When will you take me?
My mother asks the stream.

Bourn

by Zanele Mangundu

I know it when the sun sets far below the trees,
And the brittle hand of my mother
Has vanished beneath the frozen bourn,

When the critters begin to chirp
And the water hardens
into dark thick ice.

I walk upon it and press my face to its surface
And examine the creases now bestowed upon my face.
Through the ice, I find my mother.
And to the bourn
I ask,
When will you take me too?

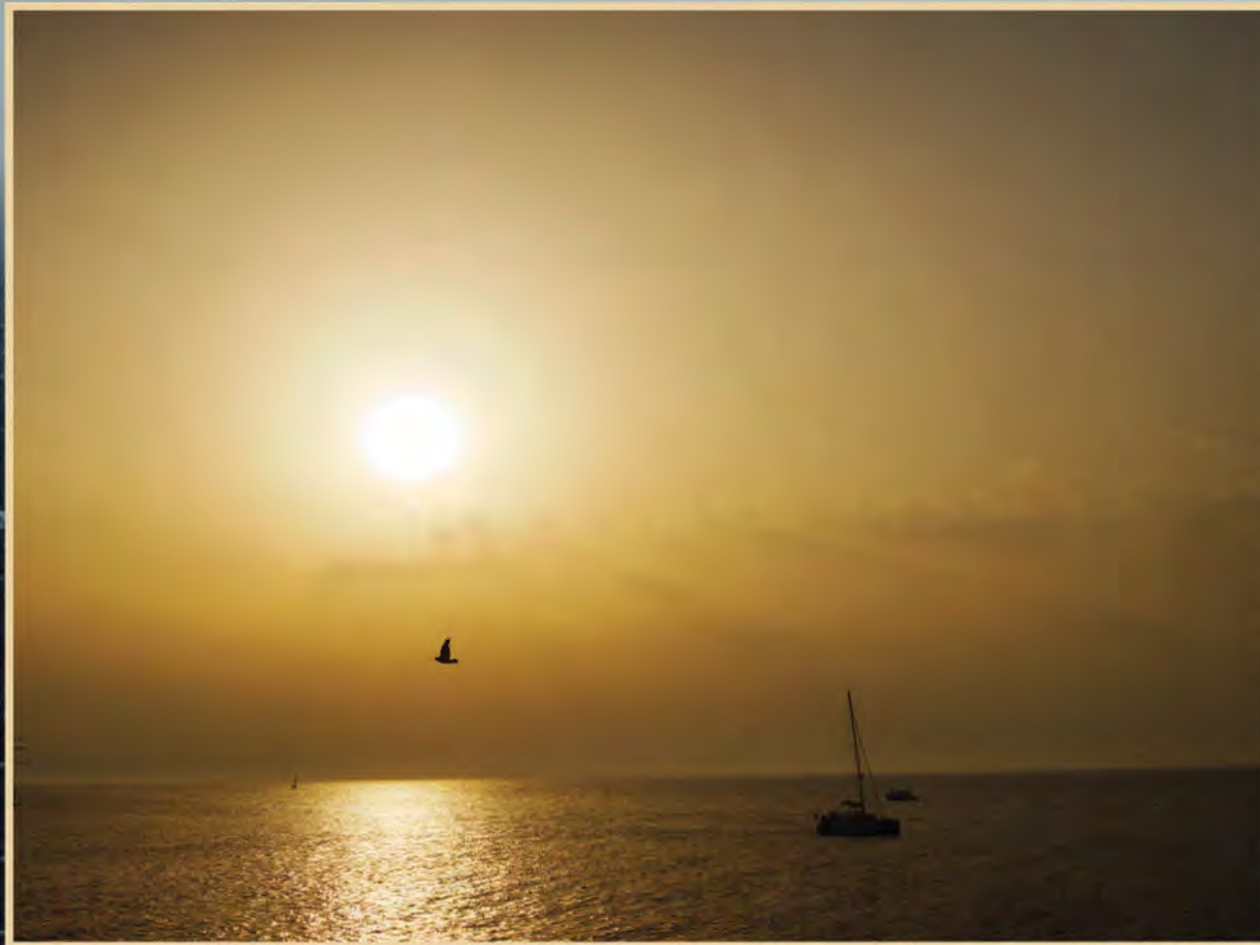


Leah Buskirk, *Twice Over*, Pen on Silk Sheet over Upholstery Collage

Between Tides

by Priscilla Le

Sand stretches in waves meeting the sea.
Light dances across its surface, reflecting the bright blue sky.
The sea is vast enough to deafen anything.
I lie back, forcing myself to meet the glaring sky.
Waves wash over me, whole,
soaking first my clothes,
then settling in my chest, heavy with desperation.
Expectations crash so deafening,
I can't hear myself.
Each surge builds crippling pressure,
inviting more water until there's no room left.
But I stay of my own volition -
just for a day,
I don't want to live a life built from others' ambition,
fingers straining to hold on,
while it's slipping away
So I let the depths hold me.
I'll face everything,
but maybe not today.



Sofia Fulton, *Volare*, Digital Photography



Dorian Parker-Rollins, *Salvation*, Digital Photography



Natalie Kral, *A Handful of Heritage*,
Clay with Mixed Media

An Ode to Nature

by Annie Scheffy

Everyone obtains it differently,
Not happiness but joy.
The deep state of happiness,
One that makes your heart feel whole,
The greatest feeling.
A sensation that tingles through your body.
A moment that rocks your world
When you reach this state it's the best feeling,
The feeling that lights up your world.
It makes the dark times better and the good times great.
The intense emotion
Can be overwhelming.
It makes your stomach hurt.
It makes your cheeks sore.
A feeling everyone experiences,
Joy is a lasting state of contentment.
A feeling everyone experiences.
It makes your cheeks sore,
It makes your stomach hurt.
Can be overwhelming
The intense emotion.
It makes the dark times better and the good time great,
The feeling that lights up your world.
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The deep state of happiness.
Not happiness but joy,
Everyone obtains it differently.



Abby Colwell, *Upholding Earth*,
Stoneware with Colored Glaze



Army Man, *Won't You Come Home?*

The lines between this day and the next blur.
The lines between here and there mesh.
I am but a moving part of something much bigger.

A cog in the wheel.
You are nothing, he said.
There is no rest for the working man.
I got used to the routine.
Does she still love me?
I don't know.

This life is no longer mine.
I no longer like my room.
The world outside my room seems to large.
I know too much, now.
You've changed, she said.
There is no rest for the working mind.
Yet me life is unravelling.
Do you still love me?
I'll never know.

by Makenzie Williams



SMALL CHANGES

by Jenelle Saavedra

Aging begins with small changes
Time slows and moments deepen
Wrinkles tell stories of joy
Laughter grows softer but richer
Lessons settle into the heart
Mistakes turn into wisdom
Life feels calmer, more kind
Memories gain a golden glow
Growing older feels like a gift
Aging is sweet, not something to fear

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Elle Russell, *A Piece of Ghana*, Oil on Wood with Fabric



Yanka Zhang, *Senny*, Oil on Canvas

The Light of Us

by Jessica Setiawan

The sun writes invitations in the light,
As we arrived, we were ready to bask in the light.

From slides that looked like serpents, steep and high,
We fell in screams, a blur of skin, in the light.

The wave pool churned a chaos cool and deep,
A thousand shattered diamonds catching light.

Our laughter was a currency we spent,
Richer than the shiny coins of noon-day light.

We floated down the lazy river's bend,
And watched the spotted trees drink the light.

The day, ended with a sweet and quickly melting cake,
And each candle was blown, a wish sent towards the light.

So let the world outside grow dull and dim,
My friend, we are alighting within the light.



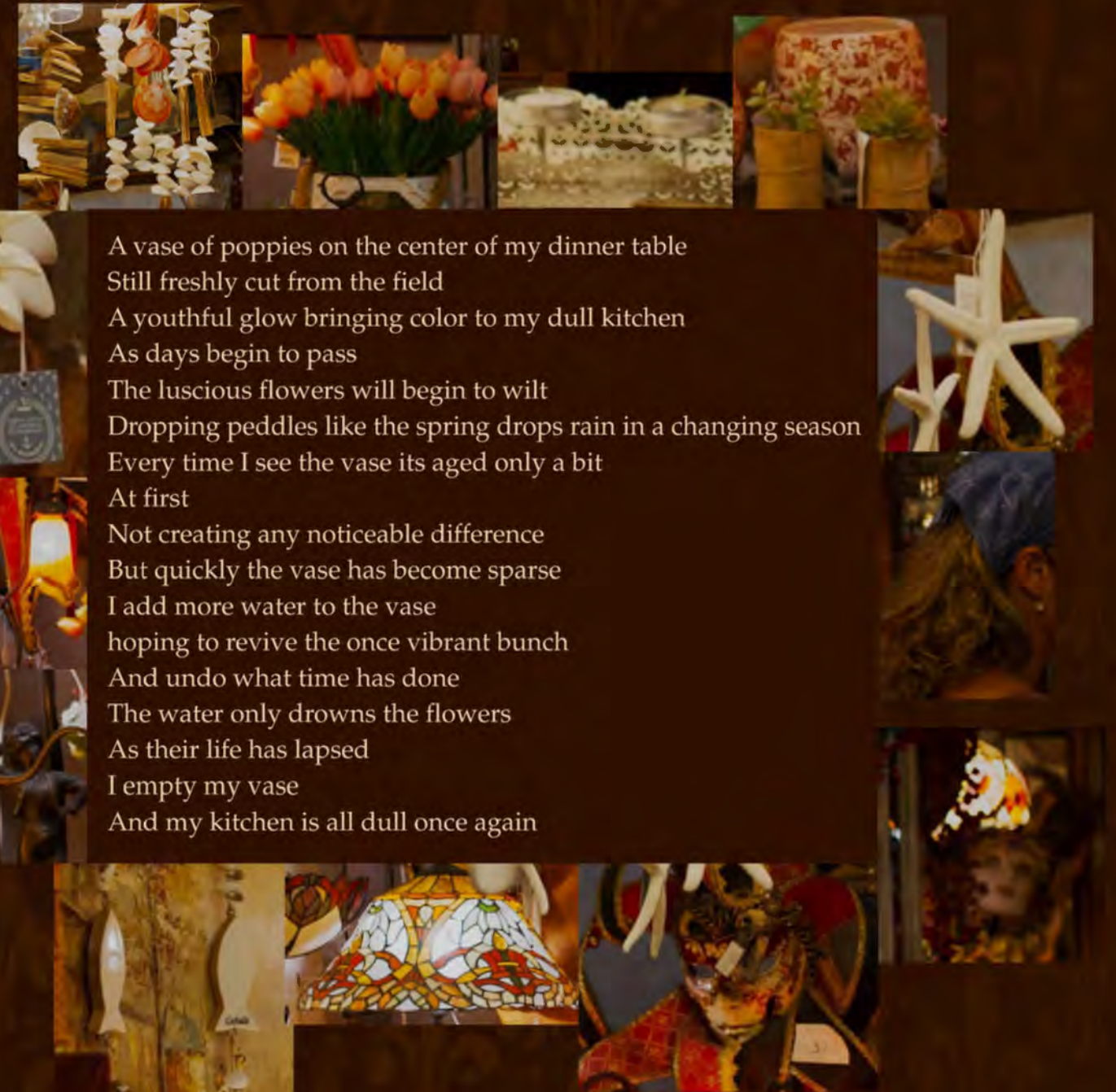


Sofia Fulton, Oggettistica, Digital Photography



POPPIES

by Josie Reed



A vase of poppies on the center of my dinner table
 Still freshly cut from the field
 A youthful glow bringing color to my dull kitchen
 As days begin to pass
 The luscious flowers will begin to wilt
 Dropping peddles like the spring drops rain in a changing season
 Every time I see the vase its aged only a bit
 At first
 Not creating any noticeable difference
 But quickly the vase has become sparse
 I add more water to the vase
 hoping to revive the once vibrant bunch
 And undo what time has done
 The water only drowns the flowers
 As their life has lapsed
 I empty my vase
 And my kitchen is all dull once again

Self Cave

by Wren Schuman

Take a moment to center alone,
Life can be overwhelming for all.
Let your light be shone,
And keep your head up tall.
Love is all around,
While sometimes hard to see.
Look left, right, up, down,
And there the answer will be.
Be childish, be clumsy, be wrong,
Mistakes are always okay.
Dance to your own song,
Move with the music, and play.
No one is always right,
Everyone has their own thing.
So, let light be light,
And hear the bells ring.



Adeline McGuire, *Isolation*, Mixed Media

Let the Rain Strike

by Anna Makovich

Are are we nothing but lumps of sugar on a frigid, rainy day?

Do we condense unto our sweetness and ignore the molten skies, glazing over this vat of toxic grey? Puckering lemon drops and binding taffy can't hide the crumbs of cruelty; we let our bright wrappers label what we're made of, allow a measly mark determine our expiration date. Pray tell, how much gum has been chewed up beyond recognition before it was spat out dry and flavorless onto the cold pavement of some decaying city street to be picked on later still? I say, let the rain strike. Let the sobering droplets of clarity, the whispers of humanity, chase the fog out and melt these pitiful packages that hide our cowardice as it turns its ugly snout from the vacant vending machine—all the while, the homeless starve, and the elders, fragile with time, are carted away, ignored, and another patient dies from a system that can't afford to treat a curable calamity. And yet it's the bitter that suffer and know this, not the neat and proud candies lined up on the shelf, too worried about how high of a price they can sell themselves for than to think of the wasted licorice lying on the convenience floor.

So Let The Rain Strike!

Watch The Malice Melt

As The Honeyed Lies Ignite

And The Recipe Is Tossed!

LET IT RAIN!



Dorian Parker-Rollins, *Coins*, Paper Mache with Acrylic and Beading

Bitten

by Celia Albi

Can you give me morality that is good?
Give me what will pacify my bellowing infant?
Give me a dollhouse so perfectly clean?
Give me a dog that will never bark?
Give me an eraser which leaves no ghost of graphite?
Give me nails that don't know what it's like to scratch?
Give me the apple instead?
Because I wouldn't have bitten into it; it would remain,
Glassy, ruby, unbruised, clothed,
In my bedroom, an ornament rather than an organism.
I could give it safety.
Give it everything it needs by giving it nothing.
But when she bit it, she was given the burden to know the taste,
Honeyed, crisp, rich.
Given how great it is to be bitten but sweet.

Natalie Kral, *Split at the Roots*, Clay with Acrylic



The Persistence of Memory

by Abigail Getachew

Clocks melt in the sun's slow breath,
time drips softly across the sand.
Moments bend, refusing to end,
as dreams dissolve into day.
A lonely branch holds what's gone,
a face without motion or name.
Silence stretches—endless, still—
where memory forgets its frame.



Leah Buskirk, *Sweet in My Memory*, Acrylic on Cyanotyped Canvas





Sireen El-Awady, *Last Light*, Gouache on Canvas



Tell Me From The Beginning

by Sabrina Williams

So what's your story?
Fake between paper thin lines of lies
Or out front in the true state line
Fighting for rights or silent in the night
To hide or to seek within the eyes
Black glistening skin, among many men
Resurrecting and redirecting
Changing history for foundation of the ground
To know that we can smile now
And be proud
Watching the sunrise and sunsets
Then saying that "it's okay now"
Being blessed with a test
Writing me is all I know to be
So I ask again
What is your story?
Is it writing someone else's ideas in the complexity of your own?
Or is it finding where your story starts
To be able to end it
Reading and writing the creation of one
One that becomes another
And even eventually become one

Lilly

by Chayse Lalla

In loving memory, the fur was an unshakeable reminder of her presence, toys laid in the basket, half chewed bones, laying with no more purpose in our house. The discolored part of the couch stayed indented with the weight of her loyalty, comfort, that her life had held. The two silver bowls now buried in the bottomless, ever sinking, pits of the closet, resemble the pointless holes dug in the backyard, stemmed from her curiosity, now both a drought. The squirrels in the backyard wait to be chased as the neighbors are introduced to an unfamiliar silence in the morning. Her bark no longer fills the ambience. *Lilly*, ceases to fill my daily vocabulary, yet, now my selection of words, once spoken to her, are limited in regards to grief and a loss of meaning for them. The void of her presence is only noticed by the mass of brown missing from laying on the floor. Her scratches on the wooden floors remain along with the smudges on the windows from her biometrics.



Max Gerber, *Golden Freedom*, Oil on Wood



Yanka Zhang, *Phases*, Digital Media

FAKING RESILIENCE

by Katherine Pozo Anchundia

Hair holds memories
And toys hold innocence
She keeps the dove close
Just faking resilience

She flew too high
But felt too hard
Almost touching the sky
But that left her a scar.

Her laughter once soft
Now whispers in the wind
The toys she adored
Lie in corners, pinned

Steps grow heavier
And her shoes don't fit
"I need new pairs mommy"
No more "I want to sleep

"I want to grow mommy"
But it's too hard
Now I have to say goodbye
To the child she once was

ELEGY OF HATRED

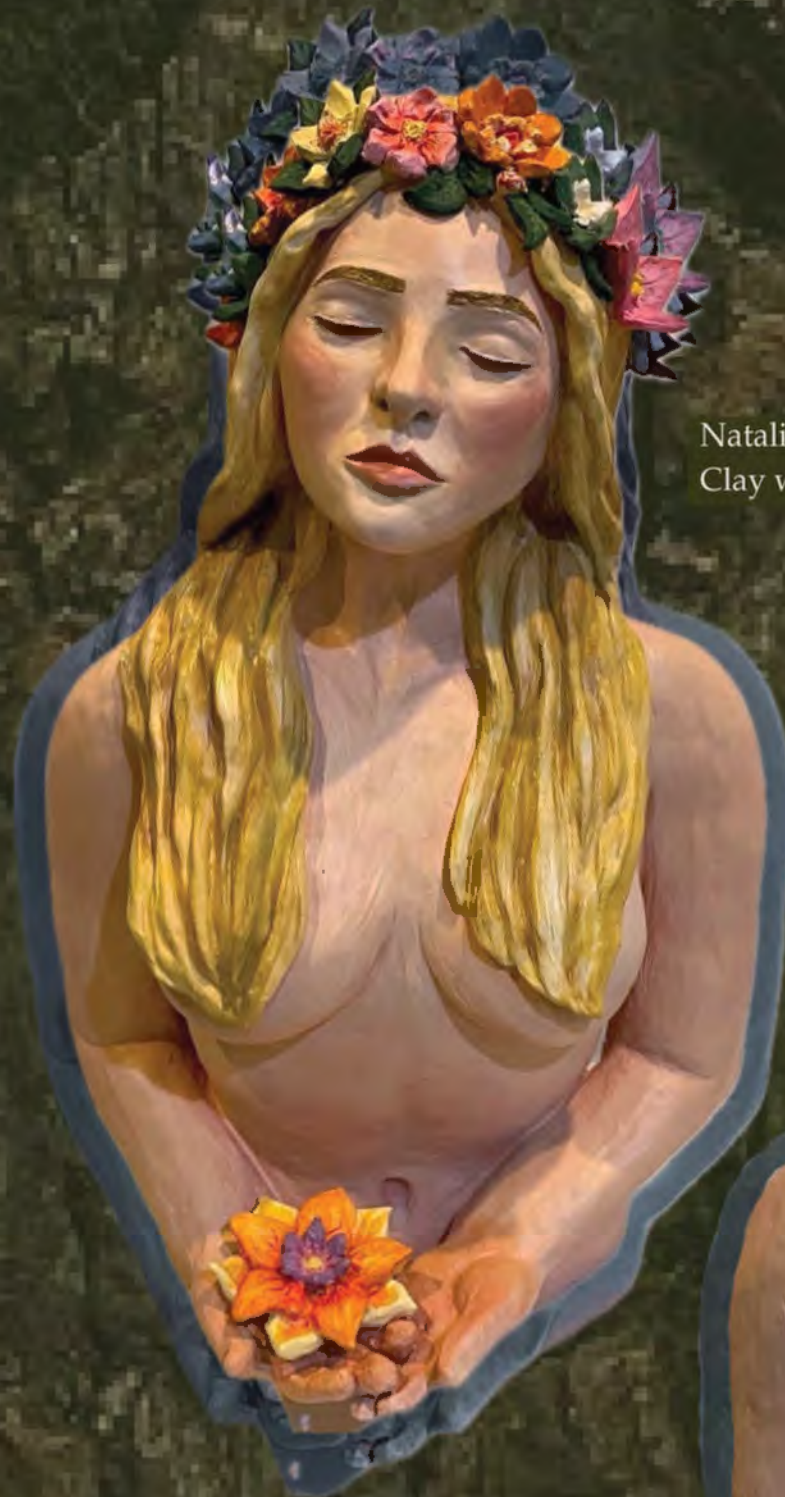
by Elsa Stano

I make a fire on the naked concrete
Fueling it off of the active surroundings
That are unaware of my messy creation.
They don't know the fire is growing
Off of their stupid opinions and
Idiotic sayings and foolish actions.
The fire grows until it burns my skin,
My head heats as I take in more of my surroundings
And more of their empty-headedness.

My fire takes my body,
Cutting flesh and breaking bones.
I cry for my fire to stop hurting me.
My tears fight against the fire I created.
The blue streams wash away the red flames.
My head becomes blank, and left alone
Is the hate I had for many
Who don't care about what I think.
All I'm left with are scars.

Adeline McGuire, *Doom*,
Oil on Canvas





Natalie Kral, *Born of the Huldra*,
Clay with Organic Media and Acrylic



THE OAK TREE

by Andrew Brown

the first time I felt butterflies
we were sitting outside by the oak tree
your head met my shoulder,
I was nervous, anxious, excited

I had never been in love before
but as my fingers brushed through your soft hair
your eyes carried a fond look everytime they met mine

the second time I felt butterflies
was with another boy
people walked by, but we didn't care
we talked for what felt like hours

I had never laughed so hard until then
he smiled and took my hand
he wanted me to know this wasn't wrong
maybe that's why I stayed with him

the last time I felt butterflies
your girlfriend came over
you stood and took her in your arms
and walked away as if I wasn't even there

I stayed by the oak tree
my head rested in my hands
left with a fragment of who I really was
remembering the first time I felt butterflies

Nights Velvet Cloak

by Nathan Hailu

The night descends, a velvet, somber cloak
And stars begin their silent watchful sweep
In shadows deep, where silent terrors croak

While dreams flourish, hopeful spoke
The world succumbs to slumber deep
The night descends, a velvet, somber cloak

The moon, a pearl, the darkness of the sky we stoke
As souls find solace in their sleep
In shadows deep, where silent terrors croak

The wind whispers tales that softly choke
Through rustling leaves secrets it does keep
The night descends, a velvet, somber cloak

With gentle hands, serenity invoke
Let worries fade, and peaceful visions reap
In shadows deep, where silent terrors croak

Till dawn arrives, where golden sunlight breaks
In tranquil rest, your silent vigil keep
The night descends, a velvet, somber cloak
In shadows deep, where silent terrors croak



Leah Buskirk, *Self Portrait*, Oil on Canvas

ABOUT OUR EDITORS

SOFIA FULTON

Sofia has been a member of Colophon since her sophomore year and currently serves as the Editor in Chief. She loves reviewing the various submissions and managing spread design through revision and feedback. She is also extremely excited for everyone to see this fantastic edition of Colophon. Sofia plans to attend the University of Vermont, where she looks forward to continuing her involvement in publishing.

LEAH BUSKIRK

This is Leah's second year in Colophon and first as the Art Editor in Chief. As a passionate artist and avid reader, she has loved having the opportunity to encourage the phenomenal creatives at THS to get their work recognized and published. Getting to delve into the more technical aspects of the magazine has been one of her favorite challenges of her senior year. Next year, she will be moving to Philadelphia to begin her career in Music Production.

CLAY SCHULTZ

This is Clay's third year in Colophon and first year as an associate editor. He is thankful for all the work the seniors put into Colophon, which has helped to create an inspiring environment and encourage submissions. He is grateful for the creative outlet Colophon provides to the Towson community, and loves the community that the club brings each year. He hopes to help continue showcasing students' creativity as a leader next year.

KEIRA DWYER

Keira has been a member of Colophon since her sophomore year and currently serves on the board as a co-social media manager. She enjoys reviewing the amazing art and writing submissions created by our talented student body. As a graduating senior, Keira plans to attend Towson University and is excited to apply the skills she has gained from being a part of this club to her life after high school.

JOSIE PARASKA

Josie has been a part of Colophon for two years, helping design the magazine and being one of the leaders as the co-social media manager. She loves to create and consume art, and appreciated the opportunity to work on this magazine. She is looking forward to seeing what Colophon will create next. Josie is a graduating senior and plans to attend Fordham University in the fall.

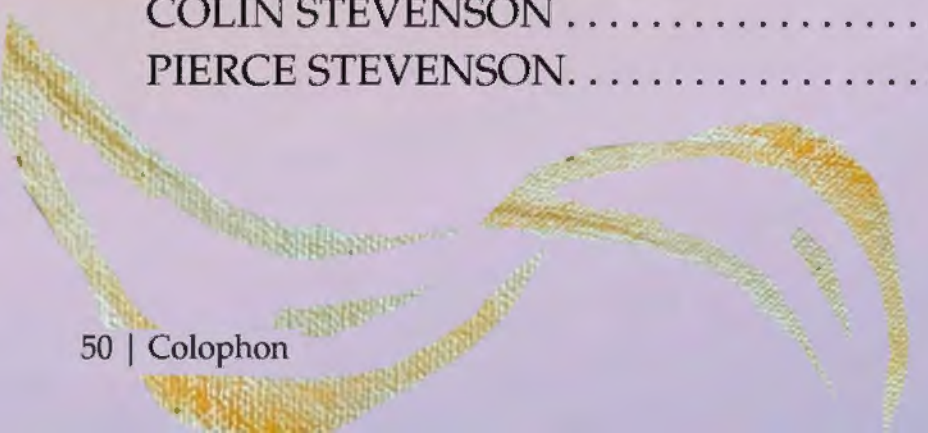
LILLIAN BALDUS

This is Lily's third year in Colophon and first as an associate editor. She is grateful for all the hardworking seniors who have made Colophon such an inspiring environment and for those who contribute their art and writing to the club. She hopes Colophon will continue to showcase the creativity and talent of Towson students.



SPREAD DESIGNERS

<u>Name</u>	<u>Pages</u>
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FROM THE SENIORS

After months of reviewing, editing, and celebrating our collaboration through spending our meetings elbow deep in Crumbl Cookies™, it is hard to believe that our time with Colophon is coming to an end. The amount of care and creativity that went into this magazine has been incredibly inspiring, and being part of this process has been a meaningful experience for us all. What made this year so special was not only having the opportunity to design a magazine with such a dedicated staff, but getting to witness their ability to overcome time constraints and various discussion-based challenges. Colophon has fostered an open and welcoming community, filled with students who are passionate about art and literature, and are committed to supporting one another. It has been a privilege to work alongside people who care so deeply about highlighting Towson’s diverse artistic and literary talents and putting together a collection that authentically represents our school.

We are so proud of this edition of Colophon, and deeply grateful to everyone who contributed to its creation. From reviewing submissions and selecting pieces to designing spreads and revising layouts, every step of the process required diligent work and patience from our peers. More than anything, it was rewarding to see so many different ideas and perspectives come together in one publication to reflect our community. A huge thank you to Mr. Szymanowski for all of his guidance throughout this process. Without him, none of this would have been possible. We would also like to thank all of our underclassmen for taking initiative in completing work outside of meetings and thoughtfully providing valuable insight. We know Colophon will be in capable hands moving forward and are excited to follow its publication for many years to come.

We could not have asked for a better group of people to share this experience with.
— Sofia, Leah, Keira, Josie, Elle, Selah, Max, Minhae, and Noelle



MISSION STATEMENT

For decades, Colophon has had a singular focus that has driven it to publication: giving people a voice to exchange emotion and express personal insight into our common human experience. It has been over sixty years since its foundation, and as the community that shapes it have evolved, Colophon too has grown, passing through temporal portals to adapt to its new environment. The creative arts magazine's annual efforts have culminated in a haven of creation, to protect, feed, and display to the world the minds of students.

Colophon lives through its student body, a collection of more than 1,000 minds and over 100 dedicated faculty members, without which there would be nothing to publish at all. The organization accepts submissions from grades 9-12 for consideration. The student body is diverse, harboring multilingual students, therefore as a tradition, Colophon has published at least one work of literature in a different language, this year's work being in French.

SUBMISSION POLICY

Colophon is currently accepting submissions for its 2026-2027 edition on our website, thscolophon.org. To submit, navigate to the "Submit" section of the website and fill out the information required in the form, then attach the file containing your piece. Acceptable submissions include, but are not limited to, painting, drawing, sculpture, photography, poetry, prose, and music. To see digitalized past publications and for more information, access our website thscolophon.org. Contact Colophon on Instagram at [@thscolophon](https://www.instagram.com/thscolophon).

EDITORIAL POLICY

The extracurricular club begins by assembling returning staff and incoming members to a preliminary meeting. Here, the club clarifies the purpose and need behind Colophon, identifies the direction envisioned for the year, and outlines general meeting times after school. A standard is established and clarified to all Colophon staff for the evaluation of creative works. The club members promote submissions to be judged anonymously, encouraging all students to volunteer any work they have through the Colophon website. Literary submissions are divided into anonymous sets. Each piece is evaluated individually by all Colophon staffers, and given a grade for their technique, expression of emotion, and unique insight. Similarly, art submissions are also divided into anonymous sets, which are evaluated by the entire staff through democratic voting. Criteria for artwork centers around the quality, originality of thought, and innovative use of the medium. As the year progresses, editors narrow down the list of accepted works. As the club moves into the design phase, editors consult with writers to suggest edits for syntax or literary development in their writing pieces. Art pieces are photographed or scanned to ensure high quality images. As final edits are made, the layout and the pairing of art and writing pieces are organized through a general meeting. The Colophon staff creates and designs spreads on Canva before electronically submitting the magazine for printing through Blurb, where those interested in owning a physical copy can purchase one.

COLOPHON

All body text and bylines are printed in 12 point Palatino. Title fonts are unique to each piece and chosen by their spread designers. All layout, typesetting, and artistic design is executed using Canva.